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Cover illustration *Crowned Ganesha*, c.1720
(see pp.358–9)

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123
Shiva receiving
the Ganges
in his locks,
cave shrine,
Tiruchirapalli,
c.600–30

Cut into an isolated outcrop of granite in the Tamil country of South India and overlooking a large irrigation tank is a small, shallow cave containing three empty shrines in its rear wall. What makes this simple cave at Mandagapattu worthy of attention is its inscription, which proudly proclaims that Pallava king Mahendra (r. c.600–30) had created a home for Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva 'without the use of bricks, timber, metals and mortar'. We have seen that rock-cutting was a long-established technique in western India, but clearly it was a rarity in the far South. One reason why stone was adopted so much later there may be because the South had first to disassociate it from the funerary connotations acquired in an area where ancient megalithic tomb cultures had once prevailed. Mahendra seems to have been enthralled by the technique of rock-cutting; having cut this first cave, he went on to create several more, most overlooking a reservoir, thus confirming the importance of irrigation works to the prosperity of his kingdom.

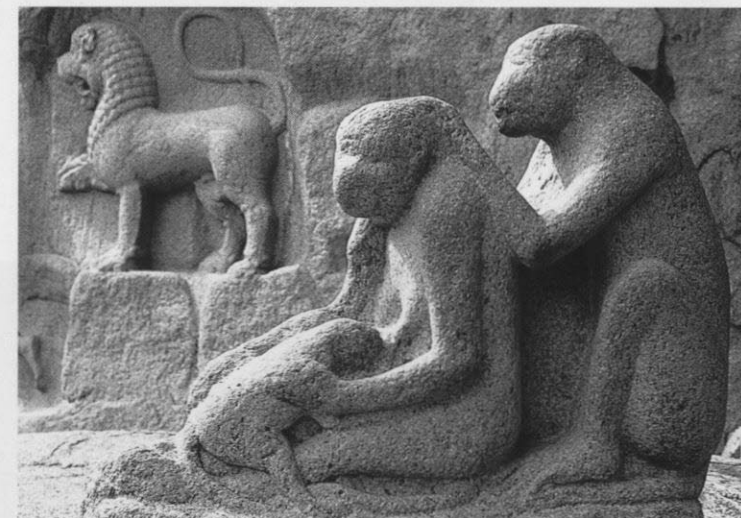
One of Mahendra's last caves is cut half-way up a granite hill at the centre of the town of Tiruchirapalli (Trichinopoly), overlooking the Kaveri, the sacred river of the South. A shrine for a *linga* is cut into one side wall, while opposite is a superb sculpted panel portraying Shiva holding out a strand of his hair to receive the heavenly Ganges in his locks (123). Mahendra's poetic inscription states that he created this cave high on the rock because Shiva had notified the king that he would not be able to admire the beauty of the Kaveri from the ground.

Mahendra was the third ruler of the line of the imperial Pallavas founded by Simhavarman around 550. He was a remarkable man – a poet, the author of at least two plays, an accomplished musician and a connoisseur of the arts. He

expanded the small kingdom he inherited in the Madras region, with its capital at Kanchipuram, to Tiruchirapalli and the Kaveri. It appears that the site of Mamalai or 'great hill', located along the coast some 65 km (40 miles) from the capital, was first developed by his successor, Narasimha (c.630–68), titled Mamalla or 'great warrior', who saw its potential as a port town for the Pallavas. He widened and deepened its inlet to accommodate large military and trading vessels, then marginally altered its name to Mamallapuram, to reflect his own title. From this new port he sent two naval expeditions to Sri Lanka to help reinstate the Sinhala prince Manavarma. Ships also sailed to southeast Asia; a Tamil inscription found in Thailand, at the site of Takua Pa, testifies to southeast Asian commerce with the Pallava region. A poem written by the eighth-century Vaishnava saint, Tirumangai, speaks of the port where 'ships rode at anchor, bent to the point of breaking, laden as they were with wealth, with big-trunked elephants, and with mountains of gems of nine varieties'. Mamalla fought numerous battles against the Chalukyas of Badami; yet, he apparently had sufficient leisure to devote time to Mamallapuram, commencing the process that has left it a veritable riddle in stone.

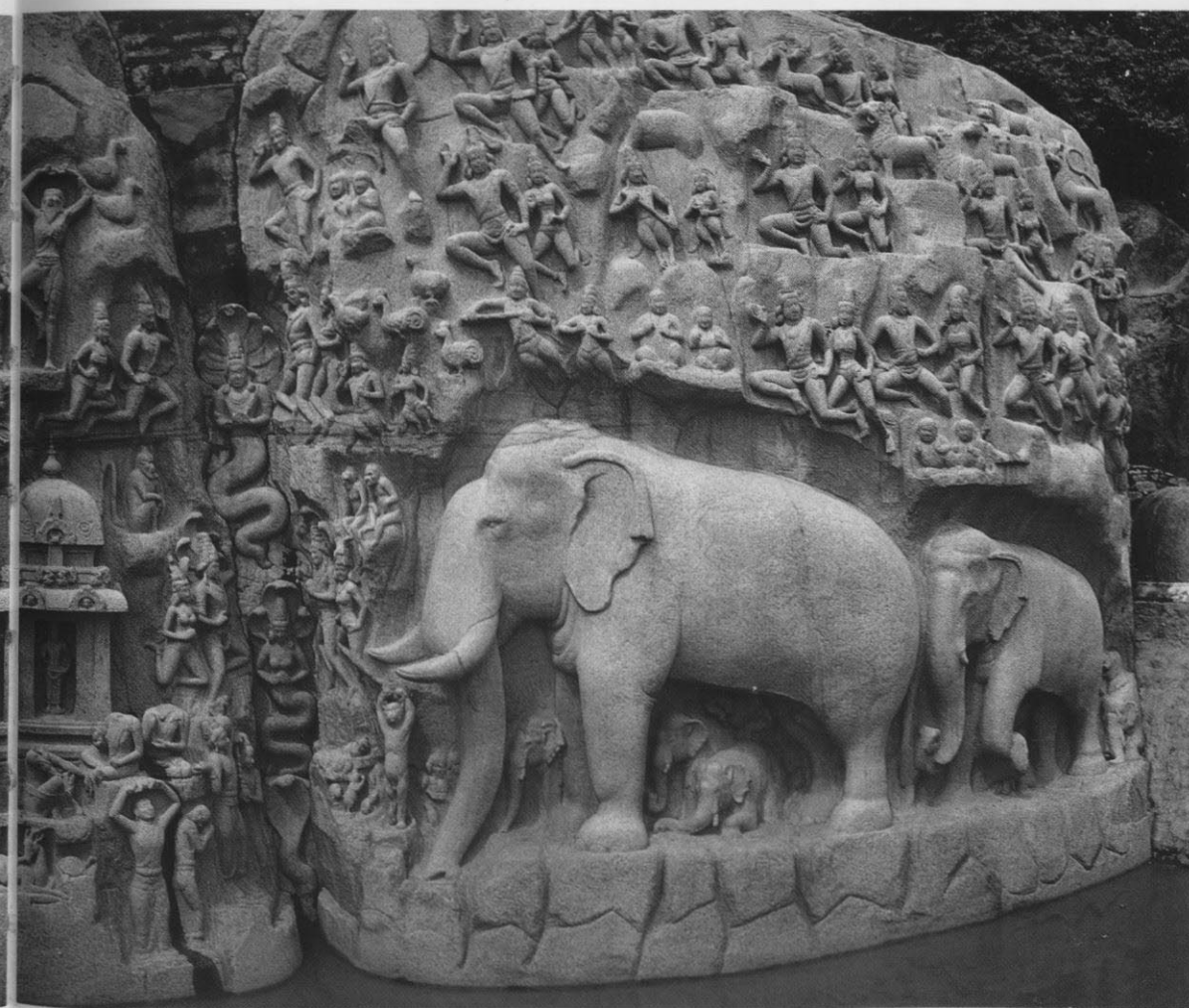
Today Mamallapuram is a deserted site except for its stone cutters and local traders who sell a variety of wares to tourists; there are empty stretches of sandy beachfront with just a few fishermen plying their trade. Inland, cut into a great outcrop of hard, grey granite, and dotted here and there amid the wind-swept sands, is a series of granite monuments of four distinct types – entire cliff faces transformed into sculpted tableaux; rock-cut monolithic shrines created out of single boulders of granite; rock-cut caves with pillared façades; and structural temples built by piling stone upon stone. In addition, there are rock-cut throne seats with rock-cut bolster cushions, rock-cut cisterns, a charming monkey family cut in the round (124) and several rock-cut animals with hollowed-out shrine niches. Added to the staggering variety of monuments is the curious fact that over half are unfinished.

124
Monkey family,
Mamallapuram,
7th century



Among the many questions posed by Mamallapuram is the specific purpose of the monuments; several features seem to contradict a religious reading of the site. Yet another issue concerns the authorship of the monuments. While several inscriptions exist at the site, most are in the nature of titles or *birudas*. Titles on one monument include *Narasimha* (not only the name of two Pallava rulers, but also the Man-lion incarnation of Vishnu), *Kamalalita* (playful with love), *Nayanamanohara* (pleasing to the eyes), *Ranajaya* (victorious in battle), *Niruttara* (without superior) and several others, all of which could be assigned to various kings. Only the last monarch, Rajasimha (r. c.700–28), has left actual foundation records.

There are two divergent theories regarding the dating of the monuments. The first maintains they are all the creation of a single monarch – Mahendra is suggested by some, Rajasimha by others. The second theory, of steady development, argues that the monuments were created gradually between c.630 and 728. Variations in the sculptural style at Mamallapuram make the latter more likely. In addition, granite, the hardest of stones, is extremely time-consuming to carve. When questioned about the time it might have taken to carve the great cliff, contemporary stone carvers working in the village point out



that they normally squat upon stone to cut it. The cliff would require a totally different manner of working; they suggest twenty men working over ten years. In the exploration of the site that follows, I have presented one probable scenario of development and dating.

The great sculpted cliff, 30 m (98 ft) across by 15 m (49 ft) high, stands at the centre of the site of Mamallapuram facing the ocean (125, 126). It is a dramatic creation likely to have been one of the first monuments seen by the overseas merchants and traders who berthed their vessels in the port there. To reinforce the fact that the central cleft is the Ganges, artists have filled it with *nagas* and *naginis*, snake beings associated with water. To the upper left, god Shiva appears to grant a boon to an ascetic who stands on one leg and performs penance. Immediately below, as if to declare that sectarianism had no place here, is a shrine to god Vishnu before which sits an aged sage and three disciples; beside them four more ascetics perform various rites of penance and *pūja*. On the opposite bank is a herd of life-sized elephants, with their frolicking young. And just beside the feet of the first elephant is a charming detail – a penance-performing cat who has cunningly deluded the mice with his asceticism. The *Mahabharata* epic tells of the sad fate that overtook these trusting mice, one of whom has his paws joined together in admiring adoration. If we move diagonally up from the cat, we arrive at the genuine penance-performing ascetic.

There are two schools of thought about the identity of the legend told by this tableau – either it is Arjuna's penance for Shiva's potent weapon for use in the great *Mahabharata* war, or Bhagiratha imploring Shiva to bear the force of the Ganges's descent to earth. Perhaps it was intentionally ambiguous, in the same way that contemporary literature of the seventh and eighth centuries often was. Playwright Dandin, who seems to have lived at the Pallava court of Mahendra, wrote a Sanskrit work that could be read as either the *Ramayana* or the

126
Detail of
relief at
Mamallapuram,
c.630–68



Mahabharata depending on how you split and interpreted the words. This literary genre, called *dvi-samdhi-kavya* or 'double-meaning poem', remained in favour for centuries, even though such poems were highly contrived. What was being done by a literary artist could surely be replicated by a visual artist.

But we may possibly move one step further and suggest that the tableau was intended to have a multivalent significance. A great sculpted relief, located at a port visited by foreign traders unfamiliar with sacred legend, may have been intended for viewing in the more universal terms of evolving karma by portraying a hierarchy of beings – from the lower level of elephants, monkeys and other animals, through a level of human experience to an upper level occupied by celestial beings. Also evident from the provision of a pool at its base and a storage tank above is the original dramatic intention of the showpiece: on celebratory occasions water could be let out of the tank to cascade down the cleft, recreating a flowing river. Perhaps such an effect was recreated every time the monarch visited the port, or whenever a foreign ship berthed at its docks; it was the *son et lumière* of its time. Quite puzzling though is that almost one-quarter of the cliff – its entire lower left – has not been finished. Adding to the mystery surrounding the tableau is a lesser, quite unfinished relief located close by



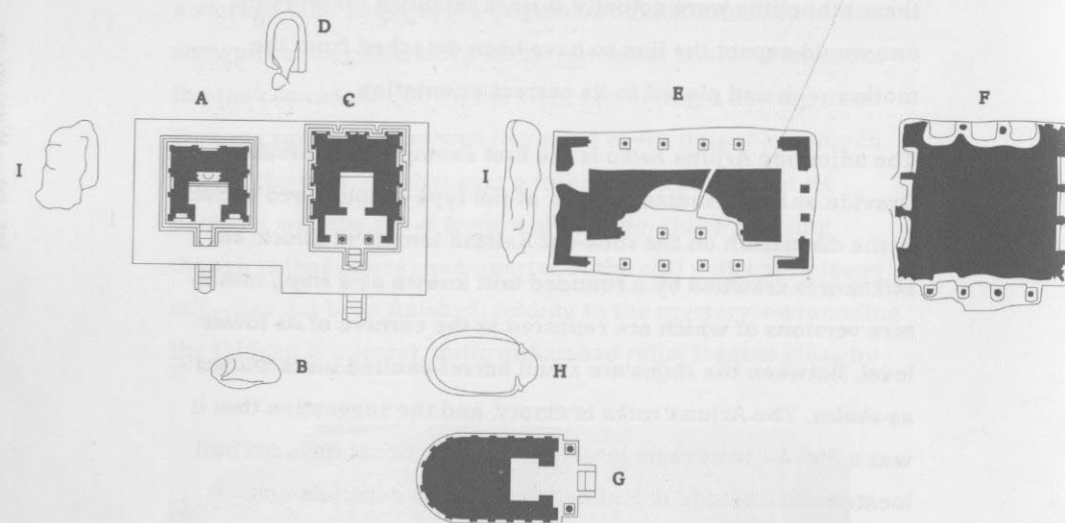
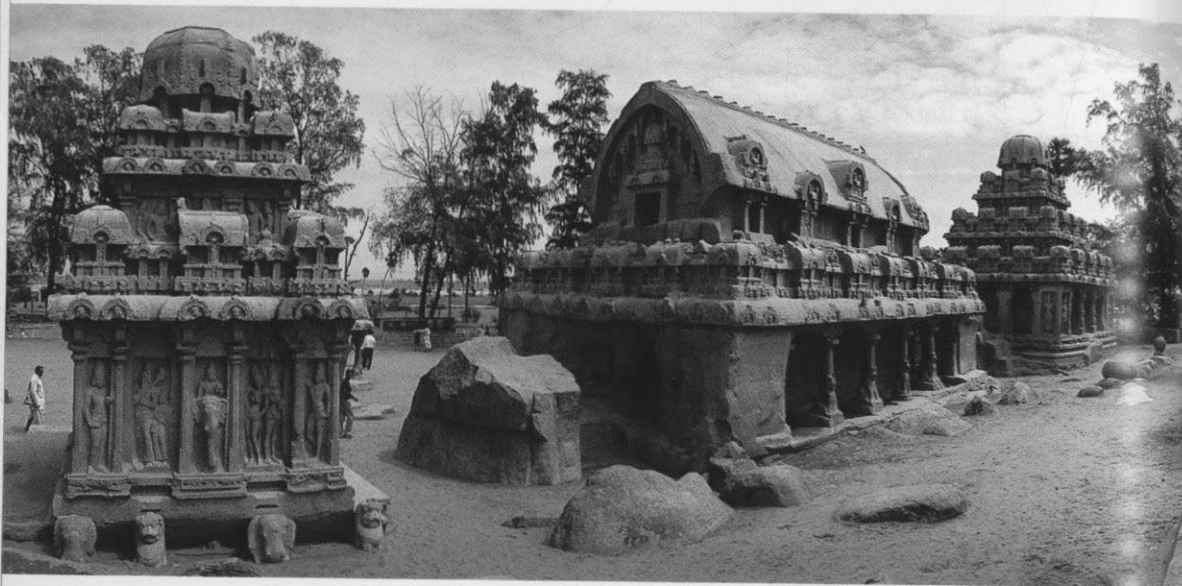
127
Incomplete
sculpted cliff at
Mamallapuram,
c.630–68

that seems to replicate the same theme (127). Was it a trial attempt abandoned because there were two clefts in the rock? Is it possible that the site represents a vast outdoor workshop?

At the southern end of Mamallapuram is an isolated group of rock-cut monoliths known as the five *rathas* or chariots, named after the heroes of the *Mahabharata* epic; the term *ratha* and the names given to each are later appellations. The *rathas* present several intriguing issues, not the least being that four of the five represent differing architectural types (128–130). The first, a stone rendition of a wooden hut with a thatched roof, is dedicated to goddess Durga whose image is carved on the rear wall while her female attendants flank the entrance. Her mount, the lion, is carved from rock that stands in front of the shrine; instead of facing Durga, the lion gazes off into the distance. If these monoliths were actually shrines intended for worship, one would expect the lion to have been detached from the mother rock and placed in its correct orientation.

The adjoining Arjuna *ratha* is the first example of a sizeable Dravida or South Indian temple, of the type encountered earlier in the discussion on the rock-cut Kailasa temple at Ellora. Its *shikhara* is crowned by a rounded unit known as a *stupi*, miniature versions of which are repeated at the corners of its lower level. Between the *stupis* are small barrel-vaulted units known as *shalas*. The Arjuna *ratha* is empty, and the suggestion that it was a Shiva shrine rests largely on a magnificent rock-cut bull located close behind it. But he has not been detached and placed in the correct ritual position as we would expect in a sacred centre. Is this because the five *rathas* are more in the nature of a workshop than a site of worship?

The Bhima *ratha* is a barrel-vaulted structure incomplete in its lower level; the partially cut stone in the interior was probably intended to be an image of reclining Vishnu. The fourth shrine of the series, the Dharmaraja *ratha*, is a taller, more impressive version of the southern temple than the Arjuna *ratha*. It reveals much about the manner in which rock cutters worked upon a



128-130

The five *rathas*,
Mamallapuram,
c.630-68

Above left

From left the
Arjuna,
Bhima and
Dharmaraja
rathas

Above right

From left the
Nakula
Sahadeva
ratha, elephant,
Durga shrine
and Arjuna
ratha

Left

Plan showing:

- (A) Durga shrine
- (B) Lion
- (C) Arjuna *ratha*
- (D) Bull
- (E) Bhima *ratha*
- (F) Dharmaraja *ratha*
- (G) Nakula Sahadeva *ratha*
- (H) Elephant
- (I) Rocks

giant boulder to convert it to a shrine, commencing at the top and working down. The two upper levels of this structure have a shrine chamber in each, the topmost featuring a relief image known as Somaskanda, of Shiva, Parvati and their infant son Skanda (*sa* [with] Uma [Parvati] and Skanda). The lowest level is solid, incompletely cut rock. Carved stone steps lead from the third to the second level, but the stone-cutters had not got around to creating steps from the second to the first level. The Dharmaraja is the only one of the *rathas* to contain inscriptions; unfortunately, they may be assigned to one of several rulers. However, the title Mamalla is engraved prominently along the stairway balustrade and may indicate that these *rathas* were commissioned by Narasimha Mamalla.

The fifth, an apsidal *ratha* known as the Nakula Sahadeva, is juxtaposed in an intriguing manner with the elephant carved beside it. The shrine may have been dedicated to either Indra or Aiyandar, both of whom ride an elephant, although the animal is incorrectly placed for a sacred context. In Sanskrit, an apsidal shrine is referred to as *gaja-prishtha* or elephant-backed. Perhaps apprentices in an outdoor workshop were asked to carve the elephant and then beside it an elephant-backed shrine.



Cave architecture, begun by Mahendra, continued to be popular at Mamallapuram. A small but strikingly sculpted Varaha cave, which lies directly behind the great cliff, was probably a Mamalla creation. A tank cut into the rock floor in front of it again stresses the significance of water. The sculptures within are imposing. One wall depicts Vishnu in his third incarnation as the gigantic boar Varaha, upholding personified goddess Earth whom he has rescued from the depths of the cosmic ocean (131). Opposite is the gigantic form of Trivikrama assumed by Vishnu as part of the fifth incarnation, after coming to earth as a dwarf and being granted three strides of land from the powerful king Bali: one stride covered the earth, the second the heavens and with the third stride he placed his foot on Bali's head. The rear walls of the cave are devoted to goddess Lakshmi lustrated by elephants, and Durga as the heroic warrior goddess. The main shrine today is empty; the cave is the only one at Mamallapuram which has a ceiling carved with floral designs that still show traces of paint.

131
Vishnu as
Varaha,
Varaha cave,
Mamallapuram,
c.630-68



132
Yali cave,
Mamallapuram,
c.700

During his reign, Parameshvara (r. c.670-700) fought several battles against the Chalukyas and the neighbouring southern kingdoms. But he too continued patronage at Mamallapuram and may have commissioned the Shaiva cave known as the Mahishamardini (slayer of the buffalo-demon); his name Parameshvara or 'Great Lord' is an epithet of Shiva. While dedicated to Shiva (the rear wall of the shrine contains a Somaskanda panel), its left wall features Vishnu reclining in slumber upon the milky ocean prior to the creation of the world, while its right wall presents the great battle between the goddess Durga and the buffalo-demon that gives the cave its name (133).

An extraordinary creation, the Yali (or Tiger) cave is located some 4 km (2½ miles) to the north of the site (132). A great boulder has been converted into a fanciful structure with enlarged heads of *yalis* or mythical lion-like creatures framing a shallow niche in the rock face. The niche is flanked by rearing

133 Overleaf
Durga fighting
the buffalo-
demon,
Mahisha-
mardini cave,
Mamallapuram,
c.670-700



lion pilasters. The rest of the boulder has been carved to present frontal views of two elephants with *howdahs* on their backs carrying images of deities. As in several other structures at Mamallapuram, it would seem that water was meant to collect in the hollow space in front of the cave. What purpose did it serve? Perhaps a sacred image was brought in procession along the beach to be placed in the shallow niche to witness a festival, and then taken back to its home site.

The reign of the last great monarch of the imperial Pallavas, Narasimhavarman II, known as Rajasimha, seems to have been relatively free of warfare, and he was able to devote his time to temple-building. The quintessential monument of his reign is his personal chapel of Kailasanatha, named after Shiva's mountain home, at his capital of Kanchipuram, 72 km (45 miles) from Mamallapuram. Oriented east-west, the Kailasanatha complex consists of a sandstone shrine with a detached hall, enclosed within a rectangular courtyard wall (134, 135). The impressive pyramidal *shikhara*, a clear progression from the Dharmaraja *ratha*, represents the southern temple in its fully fledged form. The main shrine houses a Shiva *linga*, 2.5 m (8 ft) high, and against its back wall is a sculpted Somaskanda family group. Seven sub-shrines, attached to the exterior of the main shrine, contain monumental images of Shiva some 3 m (10 ft) high, including Shiva dancing, as the enchanting mendicant, destroying demons and receiving the Ganges. We see the unmanifest in the *linga*, and the manifest in the anthropomorphic images both in the sub-shrines and in the many aedicules along the temple walls. The hall in front (the connection between is a sixteenth-century addition) carries sculpted images of four forms of the goddess. Ancient religious texts, the *agamas*, describe the hall as the embodiment of the feminine force, Shakti, and the shrine as the male energy or Purusha.

Rajasimha's engraved foundation inscription encircles the sanctum and informs us that he 'erected this extensive and wonderful house of Shiva, whose grandeur resembles the fame and the



134–135
Kailasanatha
temple,
Kanchipuram,
c.700–28

Above
View within
the courtyard
enclosure
Below
Corner rear
view of the
shrine



laughter of Shiva'. The temple seems to have been something of a family undertaking. Immediately inside the entrance is a compact, barrel-vaulted, rectangular shrine built by Rajasimha's son Mahendra, while beyond the modest entrance gateway stand eight miniature shrines apparently built by Rajasimha's queens. A considerable distance in front of the temple is a pavilion with Shiva's bull seated within it, facing the lord.

The enclosing courtyard wall consists of a series of mini-shrines. The shrines of the east and west walls carry sculpted Somaskanda images; those along the north and south walls contain, in addition to interior images, a shallow niche on their façades to accommodate further images. These interiors feature either the family group of Shiva, or Uma on her own; some are sculpted while others are purely painted forms revealed recently after the layer of lime plaster was removed. A specific programme is evident in the placement of images; for instance, the destructive aspects of Shiva are all located along the south wall, while his benign aspects are portrayed along the north. Within the courtyard of this Shaivite shrine, Vishnu appears in a range of forms that include Narasimha and Trivikrama.

A unique feature of the Kailasanatha temple is the recording of the over 250 titles or *birudas* of Rajasimha along the base of these courtyard shrines. The titles are inscribed four times, on four different levels, in varying styles of script – northern, southern and florid versions. The *birudas* celebrate Rajasimha's exploits and accomplishments. He is Ocean of Arts or *Kala-samudra*; Storehouse of Arts or *Kala-nidhi*; Sole Hero or *Eka-vira*; Victor in Battle or *Rana-jaya*; Unconquered or *Aparajita*; Devastating in Battle or *Atiranachanda*; He who Showers Gifts or *Dana-varsha*; One of Unlimited Fancies or *Atyantakama*. The titles reveal much about the personality of an ideal ruler: his beauty, temperament, valour, care for his subjects, mastery of politics, upright conduct, personal accomplishments, love of the arts and, in Rajasimha's case, his adoration of Shiva. The titles

also demonstrate the enormous difficulty of ascribing monuments, such as the Dharmaraja *ratha*, to any ruler solely on the basis of inscribed *birudas*.

At Mamallapuram itself, Rajasimha built the Shore Temple (136, 137) with its twin granite towers glorifying Shiva twice over. It bears a clear dedicatory inscription. The larger shrine faces the ocean, the smaller one inland; both carry Somaskanda reliefs on their rear walls. According to a tale narrated by poet Dandin, an image of reclining Vishnu, carved into a rocky outcrop, once occupied pride of place upon the seashore. When Rajasimha decided to proclaim the glory of Shiva at that very spot, he left the reclining image in place and even built a little pavilion around it; but then he sandwiched it between two shrines to Shiva, literally putting Vishnu in the shade. Until recently, the ocean waves beat onto and into the Shore Temple, but today a reclamation project protects it. Recent excavations have yielded evidence of a Pallava retaining wall towards the land side of the temple, making one wonder if the promontory was once an island.

There is much at Mamallapuram that remains enigmatic. After Rajasimha, there was a dynastic revolution, and a collateral

136
Shore Temple,
Mamallapuram,
c.700–28





137
Shore Temple,
Mamallapuram,
c.700-28

branch of Pallavas came to power. They too were passionately interested in art and religion, and built important temples at Kanchipuram. However, it seems they did not build at Mamallapuram. Perhaps the site was too strongly associated with the Simhavishnu-to-Rajasimha branch of the Pallavas. The reason why Mamallapuram was never completed remains a mystery. Perhaps the answer is to be found in the obscure history of the later Pallava rulers.